TEMPLETON BUILT

FREE GUIDE FOR ADELAIDE HOMEOWNERS

Before you brief an architect.

Twelve decisions that quietly set your budget long before a single trade quotes — and what each one costs you to change later.

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Twelve decisions.

WHY THIS GUIDE EXISTS

Most expensive mistakes are made before a builder is involved.

By the time we are asked to price a project, the decisions that set the budget have usually already been made — often months earlier, often without anyone realising a budget decision was being made at all. This guide lists the twelve that come up most often on Adelaide projects.

None of them are about choosing cheaper things. They are about knowing which choices carry weight, so you can spend where it matters to you.

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The twelve.

DECISION 01

The site decides more than the floor plan

Two identical houses on two Adelaide blocks can differ by a six-figure sum. Soil classification, fall across the site, machinery access, how far services have to travel and whether you need retaining are all set before a single room is drawn. Get a builder onto the block before the design is fixed.

WHAT TO DO

Ask for a site assessment, not a price. You want to know what the block will cost you before you decide what to put on it.

DECISION 02

Floor area is the number everyone watches and rarely the one that bites

Clients tighten the plan by a few square metres and feel they've saved money. Meanwhile the glazing schedule, the roof form and the ceiling heights are quietly doing far more damage. Area matters, but it is a blunt lever.

WHAT TO DO

Before cutting rooms, ask which three line items are the largest. It is almost never the extra bedroom.

DECISION 03

Roof form is a budget decision disguised as an aesthetic one

A simple gable is cheap to frame, cheap to flash and unlikely to leak. Every additional plane, valley, box gutter and parapet adds structure, labour, waterproofing risk and future maintenance.

WHAT TO DO

Complex rooflines are worth paying for when they solve something. They're expensive when they're decoration.

DECISION 04

Ceiling height ripples further than people expect

Raising ceilings changes wall framing, window sizes, door heights, joinery, plasterboard sheet sizes, heating and cooling loads and often the roof structure. It's one of the most satisfying things you can spend money on, and one of the least contained.

WHAT TO DO

Decide early and hold it. Changing ceiling height after documentation is a redesign, not a variation.

DECISION 05

Wet areas are the densest cost in the house

Bathrooms, ensuites, laundries and kitchens concentrate plumbing, waterproofing, tiling, joinery and fixtures into small footprints. A fourth bathroom costs far more than the floor area suggests.

WHAT TO DO

Count wet areas early. Relocating one after the slab is poured is expensive; deciding not to have it is free.

DECISION 06

Where you put the kitchen sets the plumbing runs for the whole house

Stacking wet areas and keeping them near the sewer connection is unglamorous and saves real money. Spreading them to the four corners of the plan is a choice you pay for twice — once in installation, once in hot water performance.

WHAT TO DO

Ask your designer to show you where the sewer connection is on the first sketch.

DECISION 07

Glazing is where budgets go quietly

Large format, thermally broken and commercial-grade glazing behaves differently to standard residential windows: different framing, different flashings, sometimes different structure. The upgrade is rarely just the glass.

WHAT TO DO

Get the window schedule priced before documentation is complete, not after.

DECISION 08

Structural spans are invisible and expensive

Every metre of open span without a supporting wall is steel, and steel needs engineering, craneage and often larger footings. Open-plan is a structural decision more than a spatial one.

WHAT TO DO

Ask what the longest span in your design is and what it costs. The answer sometimes reshapes the plan.

DECISION 09

Heritage overlays and council requirements are cheapest to discover first

In parts of Adelaide the front elevation, materials, roof pitch and demolition are all constrained. Finding out after you have paid for a design is the most avoidable expense in this entire list.

WHAT TO DO

Pull the planning overlay for your address before you engage anyone. It takes minutes.

DECISION 10

Selections made late cost more than selections made early

Every undecided finish becomes a provisional sum, and provisional sums are where budgets drift. They also create ordering delays, and delays cost money in a fixed site team.

WHAT TO DO

Aim to have major selections resolved before construction starts, not during.

DECISION 11

Contingency is not pessimism

Older Adelaide homes hide termite history, failed damp courses, unpermitted previous work and footings that were never adequate. A contingency of ten to fifteen per cent is a normal part of a competent budget, not an admission of doubt.

WHAT TO DO

If a builder's number has no contingency in it, ask where the risk went. It did not disappear.

DECISION 12

The costs outside the build contract are real

Consultant fees, council and authority charges, engineering, energy reports, demolition, driveways, landscaping, window furnishings, and temporary accommodation if you move out. None of these usually sit inside a builder's contract sum, and together they are substantial.

WHAT TO DO

Build a project budget, not a construction budget. They are different documents.

Three questions before you sign a design agreement

- ☐ What is your budget assumption for this design, and where is it written down?
- ☐ At what stage will the design be costed by a builder — and what happens if it comes back over?

- [ ] What is included if the design needs to be revised to meet the budget, and what is charged again?

Design agreements vary enormously on these three points. Asking early is not distrustful; it is the same question a good designer would want you to ask.

ONE MORE THING

Bringing a builder into the conversation before the design is locked usually reduces design fees rather than adding to them, because it removes at least one round of redesign. It costs nothing to ask.

NEXT STEP

If the numbers in this guide made you want a second opinion, that's the point.

We price every project open-book: you receive the full costing schedule, every trade, every allowance and our margin written plainly at the bottom. It is the fastest way to find out whether what you want and what you have are the same size.

A first conversation costs nothing. Bring a survey, a sketch, or just the address.

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